

Saving Our Fields - Why Adopting Agroecology is the Future for Farming in Nebraska



My great-uncle has been on our family's Nebraska farm his entire life, watching the land change as industrial farming practices became the norm. "When I was younger, we used chemicals on everything, but now we at least rotate corn and soybeans to give the soil a break," he told me. But even with small improvements, farming in Nebraska is still on edge with factors beyond a farmer's control: erratic weather, soil degradation, and rising property taxes.

Nebraska farms, like my family's, have been built around corn and soybeans, the state's most profitable crops for decades. Industrial-scale monocropping, a practice encouraged by government subsidies, has drained the soil and increased reliance on fertilizers. My uncle has adapted where he can by adding 10-foot buffer strips to slow erosion and rotating crops for soil health, yet the system is stacked against small farmers who are looking to farm more sustainably. The solution is adopting agroecology farming practices as it offers a way forward. Small farmers can build resilience by integrating diverse cropping systems, reducing chemical inputs, and working with the land rather than against it. The transition isn't simple since many farmers can't afford to risk without financial and technical support. If Nebraska wants to preserve its farmland and protect future food security, we need policies that make sustainable farming a realistic option.

According to the [International Panel of Experts on Sustainable Food Systems](#) (IPES), farming methods focused on diversity that creates natural habitats and mixed farming could double food production in 3-10 years. Agriculture plots that are cropped with [simple agroecological practices](#), including rick bunds or dikes, green manure, crop rotation, and the incorporation of terraces, mulch, and trees, retained on average 40% more topsoil, higher field moisture and had less erosion compared to conventional farms. As climate change worsens and our land becomes less resilient to irregular weather patterns, how we farm and care for the land has become more dire if we want to protect our food system. Agroecology presents a transformative solution for Nebraska farmers, allowing them to break free from extractive industrial farming models and regain control over their land and food production. It requires systemic policy shifts and a deep understanding to make it a viable alternative to those whose livelihoods depend on slim margins.

Growing up on my family's farm in Nebraska, I saw firsthand what it takes to work the land—harvesting crops, working with the community, and navigating the unpredictability of droughts and wet seasons. In some years, the yields were strong; in others, my family faced the financial and emotional strain of poor harvests. I was only eight years old then, but the challenges have only intensified fifteen years later, and our food system has moved even further from sustainability. Despite new government bills supporting more holistic farming approaches, a critical gap remains: education. Without proper knowledge and financial support, many farmers cannot transition to sustainable practices, leaving them trapped in a cycle of dependence on conventional methods. If we truly want to protect food systems and secure the future of farming, the government must level the playing field by providing financial incentives and technical support for sustainable agriculture.

My family's farm in Nebraska is roughly 500 acres, considerably smaller than corporate conventional farms. Applying agroecological methods to this current size is difficult, so applying them to a farm exceeding 1,000 acres will be exponentially difficult and costly. One way to address the disconnect between conventional farming and more sustainable methods would be to reinforce and strengthen preexisting government policies. One of them is USDA's [Conservation Stewardship Program](#) (CSP), which provides an excellent model for government support and can empower small farmers to adopt sustainable practices. This program offers financial and technical assistance for implementing conservation measures such as cover cropping and soil health improvements, directly enhancing a farm's resilience to extreme weather events like those increasingly experienced in Nebraska. Programs like CSP could serve as a lifeline, helping mitigate the economic challenges of rising property taxes and volatile crop prices in Nebraska.

In a local piece published by [Nebraska Public Media](#), a fifth-generation farmer shared his frustration and helplessness after a devastating storm wiped out his and his neighbors' fields.

[Tom Geisler](#), who manages and works on his family farm, described walking through fields of mud where all his crops were destroyed due to flooding. Many farms face bankruptcy as recovering from these increasingly frequent extreme weather events becomes nearly impossible. This underscores the urgent need for agroecological farming practices to build resilience and help the land be more suitable for changing conditions.

Agroecological farming practices align with the ethical values of environmental stewardship and respect the cultural significance of land to Indigenous communities, who have cultivated a symbiotic relationship with nature. Some argue that these practices are too costly and time-intensive for small farmers already operating on slim margins. While the upfront costs can be high, this argument ignores the long-term economic benefits. Farmers transitioning to agroecology reduce their dependence on expensive fertilizers and machinery. Studies from the [IPES](#) have shown that farms using diversified cropping and soil regeneration methods see increased yields and reduced input costs within just a few years. The real problem is not that sustainable farming is unaffordable; government subsidies favor industrial agriculture. Expanding targeted subsidies, technical assistance, and educational programs makes sustainable farming more feasible. Others claim corporate farms are necessary to meet global food demand, but this assumption is deeply flawed. According to the [IPES](#), small farms produce over 70% of the world's food using less land and fewer resources than industrial agriculture. Large-scale monoculture farms are not designed to feed the world but for short-term profit, growing commodity crops like corn and soybeans for biofuels and concentrated animal feeding operations (CAFO). Small farms using agroecology are [two to four times](#) more energy-efficient than industrial farms because they rely on natural soil enrichment and biodiversity rather than synthetic inputs.



If we want to secure the future of farming, we must act now. Start by supporting local farmers using agroecological practices by purchasing produce from local markets and co-ops instead of relying on corporate supply chains. Every dollar spent on regenerative agriculture strengthens local economies and helps shift power away from industrial farming. Beyond consumer choices, policy change is crucial. Contact your local government officials and demand they support small farmers with financial incentives and subsidies for agroecological practices. Without this backing, sustainable farming will remain out of reach for many who want to

transition. Raising awareness is key because if policymakers don't hear from their communities, they won't take action. If you want to learn more, visit your local food hub or community garden, where these practices have already been successfully implemented.

While large-scale farmers face financial hurdles, in the long run, agroecology will reduce input costs, strengthen resilience to extreme weather, and protect soil health for generations to come. We must choose whether to continue exploiting the land until it can no longer sustain us or invest in a farming system that works with nature, not against it. The future of our food depends on what we do next.